

Arthritis and Cold Weather in the UK: Why Joints Hurt More i

Many people with arthritis dread winter. Understand the science behind cold-weather pain and discover practical strategies to stay comfortable.

By **Living With Arthritis Editorial Team** · Reviewed by **Clinical Advisory Panel** (HCPC-registered physiotherapy & rheumatology nursing input) · 2026-03-08 · livingwitharthritis.org.uk

Arthritis and Cold Weather



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If your joints seem to predict the weather better than the Met Office, you're not imagining it. Research from the University of Manchester's Cloudy with a Chance of Pain study — involving over 13,000 participants — confirmed that ****humid, windy days with low pressure**** are associated with increased arthritis pain.

The Science

Several mechanisms may explain why cold weather worsens arthritis:

****Barometric pressure changes:**** When atmospheric pressure drops (common before storms and in winter), tissues in and around joints can expand slightly, putting pressure on nerves and increasing pain signals.



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****Reduced blood flow:**** Cold temperatures cause vasoconstriction — blood vessels narrow, reducing circulation to extremities. Less blood flow means joints receive fewer nutrients and more waste products accumulate.

****Muscle tension:**** We naturally tense up in the cold, which increases stiffness and reduces the shock-absorbing capacity of muscles around joints.

****Reduced activity:**** People move less in winter, and inactivity causes joints to stiffen and muscles to weaken — a double blow for arthritis.

Practical Strategies



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****Keep warm — especially your core**** When your core temperature drops, your body redirects blood away from extremities. Layering is more effective than one thick garment: - Base layer: Moisture-wicking merino wool - Mid layer: Fleece or down - Outer layer: Windproof and waterproof

****Protect your hands**** Hands are particularly vulnerable. Options include: - Thermal gloves with touchscreen-compatible fingertips - Arthritis compression gloves (worn under regular gloves) - Heated gloves (rechargeable USB options available from £15–30) - Hand warmers

for pockets

****Warm up before activity**** - Run warm water over hands and wrists for 3–5 minutes before tasks - Use a heated blanket for 10 minutes before getting out of bed - Do gentle range-of-motion exercises in a warm room before going outside

****Stay active indoors**** - Swimming in heated pools (most council pools are 28–30°C) - Online exercise classes — Versus Arthritis and Arthritis Action offer free arthritis-specific sessions - Stationary cycling or a gentle home workout routine - Yoga or tai chi — both improve flexibility and reduce pain perception

****Optimise your home**** - Keep living areas at 18–21°C - Use draught excluders and thermal curtains - Consider a dehumidifier — damp air feels colder and may worsen symptoms - Heated mattress pads and electric blankets are cost-effective joint warmers

Nutrition for Winter

Anti-inflammatory foods become even more important in cold months: - ****Turmeric golden milk:**** Warm, comforting, and anti-inflammatory - ****Ginger tea:**** Gingerols help reduce inflammation markers - ****Oily fish:**** Aim for two portions weekly (salmon, mackerel, sardines) - ****Root vegetable soups:**** Nutrient-dense, warming, and easy to prepare - ****Bone broth:**** Contains collagen, glycine, and glucosamine naturally

Key Takeaway

Cold weather pain is real, scientifically validated, and manageable. Staying warm, staying active, and eating well are your three pillars for a more comfortable winter.

Q&A

Question: What is the key thing to know about arthritis and cold weather in the uk: why joints hurt more i?

Short answer: Arthritis pain can worsen in cold weather due to barometric pressure changes, reduced blood flow, and muscle tension. Staying warm is crucial; layering clothes and warming up before activity can help. Optimise your home temperature to 18-21°C and stay active indoors. Anti-inflammatory foods like turmeric, ginger, and oily fish can also support joint health during colder months.

Question: When should I seek professional advice?

Short answer: If symptoms persist or worsen, pain is severe and unresponsive to usual relief, or you develop new symptoms, contact your GP, physiotherapist or rheumatology team

promptly.

Question: Where can I get free arthritis support in the UK?

Short answer: Versus Arthritis: 0800 5200 520. NRAS: 0800 298 7650. Free tools and guides at livingwitharthritis.org.uk.

General information only — not medical advice. Consult your GP or specialist before changing medication or starting a new programme. Emergency: 999. NHS advice: 111. Living With Arthritis UK · livingwitharthritis.org.uk